

Vim Commands

Modes, motions, and edits — enough to stop fighting the editor.

GitHub ↗

Q Filter...

Modes

Vim is modal: keys mean different things depending on the mode. The magic is composition — an operator (d, c, y) plus a motion (w, \$, }) acts on exactly that range. Press Esc to return to Normal mode any time.

NORMAL

 the default — keys are commands

INSERT

 typing text (i , a , o to enter)

COMMAND

 : line for save/quit/substitute

MODES

KEY	ENTERS
Esc	Normal mode (the safe home base)
i / a	Insert before / after the cursor
I / A	Insert at line start / end
o / O	open a new line below / above
v / V	Visual (char) / Visual Line select
Ctrl-v	Visual Block (column) select
:	Command-line mode

MOVING AROUND

KEY	MOVES TO
h j k l	left, down, up, right
w / b	next / previous word start
e	next word end
0 / \$	start / end of line
^	first non-blank of line
gg / G	top / bottom of file
{ / }	previous / next paragraph
Ctrl-d / Ctrl-u	half-page down / up
%	jump to matching bracket
42G	jump to line 42

EDITING

KEY	DOES
x	delete the character under the cursor
dd / yy	delete / yank (copy) a line
p / P	paste after / before
dw / cw	delete / change to end of word

KEY	DOES
d\$ / c\$	delete / change to end of line
ciw	change the whole word (inner word)
ci"	change inside the quotes
u / Ctrl-r	undo / redo
.	repeat the last change
>> / <<	indent / outdent a line



Think in sentences. d2w = delete two words, ci(= change inside parens, yi{ = yank inside braces. Operator + count + motion composes into thousands of edits you never memorized individually.

SEARCH & REPLACE

COMMAND	DOES
/pattern	search forward (? searches back)
n / N	next / previous match
*	search for the word under the cursor
:%s/old/new/g	replace all in the file
:%s/old/new/gc	replace all, confirm each
:s/old/new/g	replace all on the current line
:noh	clear search highlighting

FILES, WINDOWS & SAVING

COMMAND	DOES
<code>:w</code>	write (save)
<code>:q</code>	quit (fails if unsaved)
<code>:wq</code> or <code>ZZ</code>	save and quit
<code>:q!</code>	quit, discarding changes
<code>:e file</code>	open another file
<code>:sp</code> / <code>:vsp</code>	horizontal / vertical split
<code>Ctrl-w w</code>	cycle between splits
<code>:ls</code> / <code>:b2</code>	list buffers / go to buffer 2



Stuck and can't quit? Press `Esc` first, then type `:q!` and Enter to bail without saving, or `:wq` to save and leave. The `Esc` is what gets you out of Insert mode so the colon command works.